

When I was in primary school, Dad and I loved doing jobs in his old ute. Every now and again, when we were up a bush road, he'd pull over and let me sit on his lap and steer, while he simultaneously controlled the pedals, changed the three-on-the-tree gears and smoked a ciggie.

‘Just don’t tell your mother.’

(About the driving, not the smoking in a confined space with his young son.)

My parents haven’t changed.

My old man affectionately teases my sons, calling them ‘fatty’ and ribbing them about liking the colour pink, which is ‘for girls’.

This is quite confronting for my wife, who grew up in hipsterville North Fitzroy with academic parents and who spends her spare time reading books on positive childhood psychology and gender-neutral parenting.

Still, I turned out alright . . . right?

See, for all the things my parents may have got wrong . . . they got some big ones right, too.

The day my life changed forever

I was 10 years old.

It was the school holidays and, unlike my mates, who were probably kicking a footy or playing on the Atari 2600, I was working with my dad.

At the end of the day he sat me down on his knee and made an announcement:

Dad: ‘Instead of giving you pocket money today, I’ve decided I’m going to give you one of my shares in BHP.’

Me: Blink. Blink.

Dad: ‘That means you’re now a part-owner of one of the biggest companies in the world . . . and they’ll share their profits with you.’